



Rooted in tradition: The Mohammedan Sporting Club Tent at the Kolkata Maidan. DEBASISH BHADURI

This would place Sporting on the same platform as Mohun Bagan, which was the first Indian team to win a tournament (IFA Shield in 1911) after beating a British regimental team.

Mohammedan Sporting was doing the same thing by the third decade of the 19th century that significantly overshadowed the other two city giants, rendering them virtually insignificant.

The next five decades (till the middle of 1980s) would see a lot of success stories by Sporting but it gradually fell to disrepute, achieving little by way of success.

The fan base, that runs into millions across the country thanks to its religious nomenclature, started diminishing as the club regressed into a period of mediocrity with its team repeatedly failing in regional and national tournaments.

The team was also in the news for wrong reasons, such as fan violence, which became the order of the day.

And with a management unwilling to turn to a professional arrangement, the team's form and fortune hit doldrums.

After almost three decades of darkness, a new management assumed power in 2020 and tried to haul the club out of its distress. The new office bearers started looking for investors to fund and professionalise the club.

This saw the arrival of Bunkerhill, a Gurugram-based sports management company, which decided to invest in Sporting's revival. "We entered when Mohammedan Sporting management was looking for an investor as their own initiative was not generating enough funds to sustain the team's aspirations of playing in the big league.

"We did our research and found that Mohammedan Sporting had a huge potential and we started with the plan of getting the team to the I-League. The team was then playing the third tier of the national league system," says Dipak Kumar Singh, director of Bunkerhill, which owns 61 per cent stake in the team that secured its passage to the ISL.

Mohammedan Sporting entered into an agreement with Bunkerhill in October 2020.

"We started a three-year project with the aim to see the team qualify to the top tier of the country's football league, the ISL. It feels nice that our efforts bore fruit and we could reach the target just the way we had wished for," Singh, who is also the chairman of Sporting's football committee, told *Sportstar*.

The professional setup ensured that experts took charge of the decision-making process, which saw the arrival of the former assistant coach of the Russian national team, Andrey Chernyshov.

The new head coach helped Sporting reach within striking distance of the I-League title in the 2021-22 season. A loss against Gokulam Kerala ended its title hopes but that turned out to be a blessing in disguise as the door to ISL promotion was yet to be opened for the I-League champion in that season.

"Sometimes whatever happens, happens for good. Winning the league then would not have given us the promotion. Winning matters now